09

Video

Let buyers see the work

From *Business Transformation Through AI-Powered Marketing*, the Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams

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HOW TO USE THIS FIELD GUIDE

Read it. Build it. Then let AI help.

This is one of 21 field guides. Use it on its own, or as part of a complete transformation.

Read. Each section gives you the background, the best practices and real examples, including Wild West Custom Pools, a real business going through the same steps you are.

Build. Fill in the forms, in this printed guide or in the interactive PDF. Your answers are the raw material for your plan.

Accelerate with AI. The AI Tips turn your answers into first drafts, analyses and action plans. You think. AI drafts. You decide.

You think. AI drafts. You decide.

Before you start

Do two things first, whichever guide you start with: agree on the AI ground rules (people approve everything public; verify facts; protect data; keep your voice; add what AI can't), and write down your one-year goal and your ideal customer. Field Guides 01 and 02 walk you through both.

Your free extras

Bought the printed guide? The interactive PDF is yours too. Go to marketingfieldguide.ai/pdf and enter the code on the copyright page. The companion workbook (Excel) does the math for every table: marketingfieldguide.ai.

09

FIELD GUIDE 09

Video

Let buyers see the work

Video Content | Types of Video for Every Stage of the Journey | Producing Video | Getting Video Found | Measuring Video | Your Video Strategy | Sources

Video Content: Engage Your Audience and Close More Sales

Video is the easiest content to consume. Your buyer can watch you build, explain, demonstrate and answer questions without reading a word. Use it in every channel: your website, email, social media and paid media.

Video is also one of the most powerful ways to tell a story. In Chapter 9, we put it in four words: facts inform; stories persuade. A page can list your facts. A video can show a real customer, a real project and the person behind the work, in a few minutes your buyer is glad to spend.

The numbers back that up. In Wyzowl's 2026 survey, 91% of businesses use video as a marketing tool. 85% of people say they've been convinced to buy a product or service by watching a video. When people want to learn about a product or service, 63% say they'd most like to watch a short video (Wyzowl, 2026). Wyzowl makes explainer videos, so read its numbers as a strong signal, not the final word.

Video works because it does two things text can't. It shows. People love to see how the sausage is made, and a time-lapse of a build or a walk through your shop answers questions a page of copy can't. And it connects. A face, a voice and a real customer's story build trust faster than any claim on a web page.

One video can go a long way. Dollar Shave Club launched in 2012 with a single 93-second video that explained the product, the price and how to buy. The company reported more than 12,000 orders in the first 48 hours (Convince & Convert, 2018), and Unilever bought it for $1 billion four years later (Bloomberg, 2016). That's an outlier. But it shows what one clear, honest video can do.

Video lets buyers see the work before they buy it.

What AI changed

Two things changed since the first edition, and both work in your favor.

Video is now a source for AI answers. In Ahrefs' analysis of more than 3 million U.S. searches, YouTube was the most-cited website in Google's AI Overviews, ahead of Reddit (Ahrefs, September 2026). AI tools read your title, description, chapters and transcript. A well-labeled video that answers a buyer's question can now show up inside the answer, not just in a list of results. More on this in Getting video found, below.

Video is faster and cheaper to make. In Wyzowl's survey, 63% of video marketers have used AI tools to create or edit marketing videos (Wyzowl, 2026). AI can turn your notes into a script, draft a storyboard, write captions, clean up audio, cut a long video into short clips and resize it for each platform. The camera work, the people on screen and the story still come from you.

One caution: AI can also generate realistic people, voices and footage. Don't use AI to show a project, a customer or a result that didn't happen. YouTube requires creators to disclose realistic content that was made or meaningfully altered with AI, such as footage of events that never took place or a real person appearing to say something they didn't (YouTube Help). Using AI for scripts, captions, thumbnails or edits doesn't need a label. Faked footage breaks the first AI ground rule in Chapter 1: verify facts, and keep your voice.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Hero graphic.

TYPES OF VIDEO FOR EVERY STAGE OF THE JOURNEY

Types of Video for Every Stage of the Journey

Don't make video just to make video. Every video should serve one stage of your customer journey (Chapter 5) and move the viewer to the next one.

STAGE	VIDEO TYPES THAT WORK	WHAT THE BUYER GETS
Awareness	Social clips, short how-to videos, behind-the-scenes, video ads	A reason to notice you and a first answer to their problem
Consideration	Explainer videos, FAQ videos, comparisons, webinars, retargeting ads	Help weighing their options, and why you're different
Decision	Product and demo videos, customer testimonials, "meet the owner" or "meet the team"	Proof, trust and a clear picture of what happens next
Retention	Onboarding, how-to and "getting the most from it" videos	Confidence they made the right choice
Advocacy	Customer stories, user-generated video, thank-you videos	Something worth sharing, and a story the next buyer can trust

A few of these deserve a closer look.

Product and demo videos work like a salesperson who never takes a day off. They show what you sell and how it works. Start with what you already have: your sales sheets, brochures and the pitch your best salesperson gives every day.

Explainer videos replace a wall of text about what you do. They're good for services, and for ideas that are hard to show with a camera. Simple animation works well here.

FAQ videos are the easiest to make. Ask your sales and customer service teams what they hear every week, then answer one question per video. Buyers get answers outside business hours, and your team stops repeating itself. Each one answers a question buyers actually ask, which is exactly what AI answers look for.

Testimonial videos let a real customer say what you can't say about yourself. Make it easy: a short list of questions, a phone camera and five minutes. Never script a customer's words, and never use AI to create a customer who doesn't exist.

Video for paid ads. Most of the types above can be cut down for ads on social media, YouTube and display networks. Plan each shoot with more than one use in mind.

PRO TIP

Keep it short and focused. Be clear about the purpose of each video and stick to one message and one call to action. Hook viewers in the first few seconds and keep the pace up. In Wyzowl's survey, 71% of marketers said videos between 30 seconds and two minutes are the most effective (Wyzowl, 2026). Longer is fine for how-to videos and webinars when every minute earns its place.

PRO TIP

Match the production to the purpose. The quality of your video reflects the quality of your brand, so invest in good lighting, clear audio and clean editing for the videos that live on your home page or represent your brand in ads. But a how-to, a FAQ answer or a social clip shot on a phone can work just as well. Viewers forgive a plain picture. They don't forgive bad audio.

PRO TIP

Always ask for the next step. A video with no call to action is a sales pitch that never asks for the sale. Tell viewers what to do next: book a consultation, watch the next video, download the guide. Put the link in the description, on the screen and on the page where the video lives.

AI TIP

Turn your buyers' questions into a video plan

```
Context: I run [business type] serving [customer type] in [market]. Here are the questions our sales and service teams hear most, with the journey stage for each: [paste your buyer questions from Chapter 5].

Role: Act as a video marketing strategist for small and mid-size businesses.

Ask: Turn these questions into a plan for 10 short videos. For each video, give the working title, the journey stage, the video type (FAQ, how-to, demo, testimonial and so on), the ideal length, where it will be used (website page, YouTube, social, email, paid media) and the call to action.

Format: A table, ordered by which video to make first and why.

Tighten: Favor videos we can shoot ourselves with a phone. Flag any video that needs professional production. Don't invent facts about our business; put [brackets] where you need details from me.
```

Our first five videos (title, stage, type, call to action): _____

PRODUCING VIDEO

Producing Video

Good video starts on paper. A plan saves you from shooting the same scene three times, and it gives everyone, from your team to an outside crew, the same picture of the finished video.

Start with a storyboard

A storyboard is a simple sketch of your video, shot by shot.

1. **Outline the story.** Name the main message, who or what is on screen, and how you want viewers to feel when it ends.
2. **Break it into scenes.** Decide the order and how you'll move from one scene to the next. Mix wide shots, close-ups, b-roll and different angles to keep it interesting.
3. **Sketch each frame.** You don't need to be an artist; stick figures will do. Add notes on what's said, camera moves, music and on-screen text.

4 **Check the pacing.** Make sure the visuals keep up with the story and land the call to action at the end.

If you're making a video for a client or another department, build the storyboard with them. Their input up front saves you from reshooting a video that misses the mark.

↓ Video storyboard template

Build a b-roll library

B-roll is the footage that plays under someone talking: hands at work, the shop floor, a finished project, the team in action. It keeps a talking-head video moving, and you can reuse it in dozens of future videos. Make a shot list before every shoot and capture extra b-roll while the camera is out. You can also license stock footage, just like stock photos.

Find the right people for the camera

You can have the best equipment in the world, but if the person on screen isn't comfortable, viewers notice. Most businesses already have good presenters on the team; they just haven't been asked. Try a few people on short, low-stakes videos first. The owner is often the best choice for a small business, because buyers want to know who they'll be working with.

Use music with care

Music sets the mood and fills the gaps between talking points. Much of it is copyrighted, so use royalty-free or licensed music and check the terms before you publish. AI music tools are an option too; read their license terms, and remember that YouTube asks for a disclosure when AI-generated music is the main focus of a video.

Where AI helps in production

STEP	WHERE AI HELPS	WHAT STAYS WITH PEOPLE
Planning	Turning notes into a script, outlining a storyboard, writing a shot list	The message, the story and what you promise
Shooting	Teleprompter scripts, checklists for gear and shots	Being on camera; real projects, real customers, real places
Editing	Removing filler words and pauses, cleaning up audio, suggesting cuts	Final cut and approval
Versions	Cutting short clips from a long video, resizing for each platform, translating	Choosing which clips go where
Accessibility	Captions and transcripts	Checking names, numbers and technical terms

In-house, outsource or both?

If you'll make video every month, build the skill in-house. A phone, a microphone, a light and simple editing software will cover most how-to, FAQ and social videos, and AI tools have made editing much faster. If you only need a few high-stakes videos, such as a brand video for your home page, outsourcing may cost less. Many businesses do both: a professional crew for the flagship video, the team for everything else. If you hire a crew, watch how they set up shots and light a room. It's a free lesson.

AI TIP

Write a script and storyboard from your notes

```
Context: We're making a [length]-second [video type] for [audience] at the [journey stage]
stage. The one message is: [message]. Here are my notes and the facts to include: [paste
notes]. The call to action is: [call to action].

Role: Act as a video producer who writes for small business owners, not actors.

Ask: Write a script in plain, spoken language, then a storyboard with one row per shot.

Format: Script first. Then a table with shot number, what's on screen, what's said, b-roll or
on-screen text, and approximate seconds.

Tighten: Open with a hook in the first five seconds. Keep it within [length] seconds. Use only
the facts I gave you; put [brackets] where you need more.
```

AI TIP

Turn one long video into many

```
Context: Here is the transcript of our [length]-minute [video type], with timestamps: [paste
transcript]. Our channels are [YouTube, Instagram, LinkedIn, Facebook, email, paid media].

Role: Act as a social video editor.

Ask: Find the 5 strongest moments that can stand on their own as short clips.

Format: A table with start and end timestamps, a hook line for the first three seconds, the on-
screen caption, the best channel, and a call to action for each clip.

Tighten: Each clip under 60 seconds. Quote the transcript exactly; don't change what anyone
said.
```

PRO TIP

Shoot for many uses. Every time the camera comes out, ask what else you can capture: b-roll, a 30-second answer to a common question, a quick customer comment. One well-planned shoot can fill a month of content.

Getting Video Found

A great video nobody finds is a wasted video. Plan where each one will live and how buyers, search engines and AI tools will find it before you shoot.

Label every video the way you'd label a page

Most search engines and AI tools still find a video through the words around it. Some, like Google's Gemini, can now analyze a video's pictures and sound too (Google AI for Developers). Either way, clear words do most of the work. Give them plenty:

- **Title.** Say what the video answers, in the words your buyers use: "How long does it take to build a custom pool in Austin?" beats "Our Process."
- **Description.** Open with the answer in two or three sentences. Then add a short summary of what the video covers, the chapter list and a link to the matching page on your site. Don't stop at a line or two: in a 2026 study of YouTube videos cited by AI tools, description length was the metadata most closely linked to being cited (OtterlyAI, 2026). That's a correlation, not proof, but a fuller description costs nothing.
- **Chapters.** Break longer videos into labeled sections with timestamps, and write each label the way a buyer would ask the question. Viewers jump to what they need, and Google can link searchers straight to that moment (Google Search Central). Google's AI answers use chapters too: in the same study, every AI citation that pointed to a specific moment in a video came from Google AI Overviews or AI Mode (OtterlyAI, 2026).
- **Captions and transcript.** Upload accurate captions, and publish the transcript on the page with the video. Some people watch with the sound off, and the transcript gives search engines and AI tools the full text of what you said. Check AI-generated captions for names, numbers and technical terms.
- **Thumbnail and testing.** A clear, real image of the subject, with a few words of text at most, at least 1280 × 720. On YouTube, Test & Compare lets you test up to three titles and thumbnails on the same video. YouTube picks the winner by watch time, not clicks, so the winner is the version that brings the right viewers (YouTube Help).

Give each important video its own page

Google indexes a video when it's the main content of a page, with its own title and description, on a page that's already indexed (Google Search Central). So for your most important videos, such as a service explainer or a key FAQ, build a page around the video: the video at the top, a short summary, the transcript, and a clear next step. Add VideoObject structured data so search engines can read the details, and Clip markup if you want to label the key moments yourself (Google Search Central). Your developer or your website platform can handle that (Chapter 6).

YouTube, your site, or both?

For most businesses, the answer is both. Upload to YouTube for reach: it's where people search for video, and it's the site Google's AI Overviews cite most (Ahrefs, September 2026). Then embed the YouTube video on the matching page of your own site, where the buyer can take the next step. Link from the YouTube description back to that page.

If you want no ads and more control over the viewer's experience, paid platforms such as Vimeo and Wistia host video on your site with detailed viewing data. Whichever you choose, make sure the video doesn't slow your page down. Load it only when the viewer presses play.

Make videos AI tools want to cite

AI answers cite YouTube more than almost any other site (Ahrefs, September 2026). The videos they cite follow a pattern. In OtterlyAI's study of more than 100 million AI citations, 94% of the YouTube videos cited were long-form. Shorts were under 6%. Views, likes and subscriber counts made almost no difference (OtterlyAI, 2026). A small business with 200 subscribers can be cited if its video answers the question best.

- **Make reference videos.** A clear answer to one buyer question, usually 5 to 20 minutes, with chapters. That's the format AI tools cite most.
- **Use Shorts for reach, not citations.** Cut Shorts from the long video and point viewers back to it.
- **Keep important videos current.** Update or replace a video when prices, services or facts change. In the same study, newer videos had a modest edge.
- **Check what AI says.** Ask AI assistants your buyers' questions and note whether your videos show up. Chapter 6 covers how to track this.

Search doesn't stop at Google

Buyers search inside social apps too. Since July 2025, public photos, videos and Reels from Instagram business and creator accounts can appear in Google search results (PPC Land, 2025). And 49% of U.S. consumers say they've used TikTok as a search engine (Adobe Express survey, reported by Search Engine Journal, 2026).

Treat a social video like a small web page:

- **Say the words buyers search for,** out loud and in on-screen text, in the first few seconds.
- **Write a caption that answers the question,** not just a list of hashtags.
- **Check your Instagram settings.** Use a professional account, and make sure "Allow public photos and videos to appear in search engine results" is on (Settings, Privacy).

Reach buyers in other languages

If you serve customers who speak another language, YouTube can now dub your videos for you. Auto-dubbing opened to all creators in February 2026, covering 27 languages. In December 2025, about six million viewers a day watched at least 10 minutes of auto-dubbed video (The Daily Ittefaq, 2026). Treat AI

dubs like AI captions: have a fluent speaker check the first few, especially names, prices and anything that could mislead a buyer.

Distribute every video more than once

Publishing is the halfway point. Plan how each video will reach people:

- **Social media.** Post short clips natively on each platform, sized for that platform. Lead with the hook.
- **Email.** Use a thumbnail with a play button that links to the video page. Email is a strong place for testimonial and how-to videos.
- **Paid media.** Run video ads on YouTube, Meta, LinkedIn and connected TV to reach new buyers. Retarget people who watched most of a video with your next video or an offer.
- **Sales.** Give your sales team a library of short videos they can send after a call: the demo, the FAQ, the testimonial.

AI TIP

Write titles, descriptions and chapters for a video

```
Context: Here is the transcript of our video, with timestamps: [paste transcript]. The video answers this buyer question: [question]. The page on our site where it will live is [URL]. Our business is [business type] in [market].

Role: Act as a YouTube and video SEO specialist.

Ask: Write three title options, a description, chapter timestamps and a short summary for the web page.

Format: Titles under 70 characters, written in the buyer's words. A description that opens with a 2-to-3-sentence answer, then summarizes what the video covers, lists the chapters and ends with a link line. Chapters as timestamp and label, each label written the way a buyer would ask. A web summary of about 100 words.

Tighten: Use only what's said in the transcript. No clickbait, no claims we can't back up, no keyword stuffing.
```

PRO TIP

Answer one question per video. A video that clearly answers one specific question is easier to title, easier to find, easier for AI tools to cite and easier for your sales team to send. Save the "everything about us" video for your home page.

MEASURING VIDEO

Measuring Video

Views are the easiest number to find and the least useful on their own. Track the numbers that tell you whether a video did its job at its stage of the journey.

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH IT FOR
Views and reach	How many people started the video. Each platform counts a "view" differently, and the rules change. Since March 2025, YouTube counts a Shorts view the moment it starts playing; the old count is now "engaged views." Meta's "Views" include repeat plays. Compare like with like, and don't mistake a counting change for a win.	Awareness videos and ads
Impressions and click-through rate	How often YouTube showed your thumbnail, and how often people clicked. Judge it alongside how long they watched. A falling click-through rate as impressions grow can simply mean YouTube is showing the video to new people.	YouTube titles and thumbnails
Play rate	The share of page visitors who pressed play. A low play rate means the video doesn't look relevant where it sits.	Videos on your website
Watch time and retention	How much of the video people watched, and where they stopped. A sharp drop early means the opening didn't hook them. YouTube's retention report shows how many are still watching at 30 seconds and compares each video with your recent videos of similar length.	Every video
Engagement	Shares, comments and saves, and whether the comments are positive or negative.	Social and YouTube videos
Clicks and conversions	Who took the next step: a click, a form, a call, a purchase.	Consideration and Decision videos
Assisted conversions	Leads and sales where a video was one of the touchpoints along the way, even if it wasn't the last.	Your whole video library (Chapter 19, Measurement)

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH IT FOR
AI citations	Whether AI assistants cite or link to your video when someone asks your buyers' questions.	Reference, how-to and FAQ videos

Track video on your own site, too. YouTube Studio only sees what happens on YouTube. Google Analytics 4 can record when a visitor starts a YouTube video embedded on your site, passes 10, 25, 50 and 75 percent, and finishes it (Google Analytics Help). Ask your developer to make sure enhanced measurement is on and the embed allows it. Then you can see whether the people who watch go on to call or fill out a form.

Use what you learn. If viewers drop off at the 20-second mark, tighten the opening. If one FAQ video gets twice the watch time of the others, make more like it. Retarget people who watched most of a video; they've told you they're interested.

AI TIP

Find out what your video data is telling you

```
Context: Here is the performance data for our last [number] videos, exported from [YouTube Studio / our video platform / our ad platform]: [paste or upload the data, with title, length, views (engaged views for Shorts), impressions, click-through rate, average view duration, retention at 25/50/75%, clicks and conversions].

Role: Act as a video marketing analyst.

Ask: Tell us which videos are working, which aren't and why. Look at length, topic, journey stage and where viewers drop off.

Format: Three findings, each with the evidence behind it. Then three specific changes for our next five videos.

Tighten: Base every finding on the data. If the data is too thin to support a conclusion, say so.
```

Example: a video plan for Wild West Custom Pools

Wild West Custom Pools sells a long, expensive journey: projects start at $90,000, and a build takes 12 to 16 weeks once excavation begins. Buyers need to trust the builder before they ever meet him. Wild West hasn't made any video yet, so this is a plan, not results. Here's the video plan we'd build from what we already know about the business and its buyers.

STAGE	VIDEO	WHY
Awareness	A one-minute time-lapse of a build, from excavation to first swim, cut into short clips for social media and YouTube ads	Shows the work, and the finished pool, in a way no photo can
Consideration	Two FAQ videos answering what buyers ask most in the first meeting: "How much is this going to cost?" and "When can we swim?"	Answers the two Decision questions (Chapter 5) before the first call, in Dan's own words
Decision	"Meet Dan": the owner, on site, explaining why the company builds only 12 pools a year	Puts a face on the promise that the owner is on site from excavation to first swim
Decision	A client walkthrough of a finished pool, filmed with the client's permission	Real proof from a real buyer, which no claim on a web page can match
Advocacy	A short "first swim" video the family can share	Turns a happy client into the start of the next buyer's journey

Each video would live on its matching page of the site (the FAQ videos on the pricing and process pages, "Meet Dan" on the About page) and on YouTube, with captions, chapters and a link back to the consultation form.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Wild West video strip: five rounded cards.

YOUR VIDEO STRATEGY

Your Video Strategy

A video strategy has ten elements. Check off each one as you decide it.

- ☐ **1. Set clear objectives.** What should video do for you: build awareness, drive traffic, generate leads, close sales or keep customers?
- ☐ **2. Define your audience.** Which personas (Chapter 2) and which journey stages (Chapter 5) will your videos serve?
- ☐ **3. Plan your content.** Which types of video, on which topics, in what order? Start with your buyers' most common questions.

- ☐ **4. Tell a story.** What's the message, and how will you make viewers feel something? Real people and real projects beat stock footage.
- ☐ **5. Match production to purpose.** Which videos need a professional crew, and which can your team shoot on a phone?
- ☐ **6. Use AI where it helps.** Where will AI speed up scripts, edits, captions and versions? Who approves the final cut?
- ☐ **7. Choose your channels.** Your website, YouTube, social media, email, paid media and sales. Tailor each video to the platform.
- ☐ **8. Optimize for search and AI.** Titles in your buyers' words, full descriptions, chapters, captions, transcripts and a page for each important video. Check whether AI tools cite them.
- ☐ **9. Ask for the next step.** One clear call to action in every video.
- ☐ **10. Measure and improve.** Track watch time, clicks and conversions, test titles and thumbnails, and make more of what works.

↓ Video strategy checklist and video plan

Video marketing questions

Answer these with your team. Then paste your answers into your AI assistant with the video plan AI TIP above.

What are the key messages we want our videos to convey? How will we use stories to connect with viewers?

Which topics and buyer questions will our videos cover, and how do they support our marketing goals?

Which formats will work best for our audience (how-to, FAQ, demo, testimonial, explainer, social clips), and how long should each be?

How will we use video at each stage of the customer journey? Who decides which videos we make for each stage?

What is our budget and timeline for video? Which videos will we make in-house, and which will we outsource?

Who on our team is good on camera? What equipment, software and AI tools do we need?

Where will we host and publish our videos: YouTube, our website, social media, email? How will we use paid media to promote them?

How will we optimize our videos for search engines and AI answers: titles, descriptions, chapters, captions and transcripts? Who will check AI-generated captions?

What are our rules for AI in video? What will we never fake, and when will we disclose AI-generated content?

What call to action will each video include?

Which metrics will we track (watch time, play rate, clicks, conversions), and how will we measure the return on our video investment?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day video plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the video marketing questions: [paste answers]. Our team is
[team size and roles], and our monthly budget for video, including paid media, is [amount].

Role: Act as a marketing director planning video for a small business.

Ask: Build a 90-day video plan: which videos to make, in what order, who makes them, where each
is published and promoted, and what we'll measure.

Format: A week-by-week table, followed by a short list of the tools and equipment we need.

Tighten: Start with videos we can make ourselves. Keep it realistic for our team size. Flag
anything that needs outside help.
```

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